

MYLAPORE

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VULTURE CONSERVATION INITIATIVE

Led by Raghunath Krishna, the 1986 batch of The Hindu Higher Secondary School in Triplicane is taking a critical message about this bird to school students **P3**



SPARKS OF SUSTAINABILITY

Following an announcement on World Environment day, residents have clogged EcoConnectors' inbox with accounts and images of their green lifestyles **P6**



▼ The entrance of the Chennai Beach station in George Town. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



An unsavoury welcome

Deplorable conditions prevail at the entrance to the Chennai Beach station: broken slabs and sometimes, sewage overflow



T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

For months, navigating the entrance to the Chennai Beach terminal along Rajaji Road in George Town has been a challenge for commuters.

The cement and natural stone slabs at the entrance are broken, and the pathway is uneven. At times, sewage also stagnates at the entrance. Near the ticket booking area, a foul smell emanates, and unhygienic conditions prevail.

Countless commuters entrain electric trains at the terminal to Velachery, Tambaram, Chengalpattu, Tirumalpur and Kancheepuram.

Pa. Dhanraj, vice-president, Tamil Nadu Vanigar Sanga Peravai (Federation of Tamil Nadu Traders' Association), a regular traveller on the suburban railway from Chennai Beach, says: "I went in person and complained about this to the station officer; he informed me the delay is due to the contractors currently carrying out revamping work at the terminal; until then temporary arrangements should be made to make the area suitable for public use."

PLAN YOUR WEEK

Sunday satsang in Mylapore

Sri Krishna Sweets and Sri Vittal Rukmani Samasthanam, Govindapuram are jointly organising Pravah with SRIJI - Sunday Satsang programme at Kapa-

leeswarar Temple, Mylapore, 6.15 p.m. on June 21. This programme will be presented by Srinathdass Maharaj, S/o Vittaldas Maharaj, Govindapuram.

Value education programme

The International Society for Krishna Consciousness has launched a weekly value education programme for children and teens, designed to nurture spiritual and moral values through fun-filled sessions.

The programme runs from mid-June to March, with one session weekly lasting between 1.5 and 2 hours. This is offered online and offline across the city, with English or Tamil as the medium of instruction.

Centered around the theme

'Dashavatar', the programme talks about Indian culture. Children (ages 6-12) will enjoy fun-filled learning through stories, quizzes, shlokas, bhajans, fireless cooking, and arts and crafts.

Teens (ages 13-17) will be engaged in stimulating, theme-based activities, including debates, group discussions, mind mapping, and Just A Minute sessions.

For registration, visit <https://bpss.fun/bpss-annual-program/>

For further inquiries, call 8072599295.



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AGES 5 – 15

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'No vending zone' on Avvai Shanmugam Salai misused

N.K.GANESH

Over the past several months, a large number of unauthorised street food vendors and temporary stalls encroached upon the pavements and portions of the main carriageway, particularly along the stretch from Grace Supermarket / Bank of India up to DAV Boys School in Gopalapuram. This area falls within a designated School Zone and is understood to be both a No Vending and No Parking Zone. However, these violations

continue unabated from early morning until late at night.

This has resulted in forcing pedestrians including students from DAV Boys School, Church Park School, and Sunshine Sri Sharda School to walk on the main road, exposing them to serious traffic risks.

The presence of vendors, their customers, and illegally parked vehicles causes frequent congestion, severely disrupting vehicular movement on this important arterial road.

Food waste, plastic, and garbage



A quick run of the problems residents want to be addressed.
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

school vans and buses on both sides of the road, from Church Park School to DAV Boys School. These vehicles block access to residential buildings, narrow the road significantly, and create daily congestion and hardship for residents.

This locality is a densely populated residential and educational zone. The current situation has severely deteriorated the quality of life of residents and poses a direct threat to the safety and well-being of school children and the general public.

N.K.Ganesh is a resident of Gopalapuram

are indiscriminately dumped on roads and behind residential buildings. The area is also being misused for open urination and defecation, posing a grave threat to public health and hygiene.

Illegal parking

An equally serious issue is the indiscriminate parking of private

Mylapore's Singappenn special force launched



BASKAR SESHADRI

Singappenn Special force was introduced by the State government and in the Mylapore District it became operational recently with a dedicated vehicle manned by a driver. The force comprises four women police personnel who will be patrolling girls schools and colleges in this area besides important places such as temples and other prominent institutions.

Singappenn Task Force can be reached in the same number 100 and the whole team is headed by Bhavaneeswari IG. The team comprises Jayanthi, Arokyamary, Pavithra and Chittibabu, all attached to E1 Mylapore Police Station.

School gets RO plant

Chennai Elementary School on Canal Bank Road in Raja Annamalai Puram was inspected by the state minister and Mylapore MLA Venkatramanan on May 29. The Minister inaugurated an RO Plant for the use of students and teaching staff, a long pending demand of the school.

The MLA also awarded three students who topped in Class X Board Examinations.

Baskar Seshadri is a resident of Mylapore

You can
be our
volunteer
writer

Dear readers,
you can be our volunteer-writer by writing to us about issues and events in your neighbourhood. You should send the write-ups to downtownfeedback@thehindu.co.in. Letters must carry the contact number



‘Big Street Boys’ drive vulture conservation initiative

Led by Raghunath Krishna, the 1986 batch of The Hindu Higher Secondary School in Triplicane is taking a critical message about this bird to school students. On June 18, labels carrying caricatures of vultures were distributed to students of Olcott school in Besant Nagar.

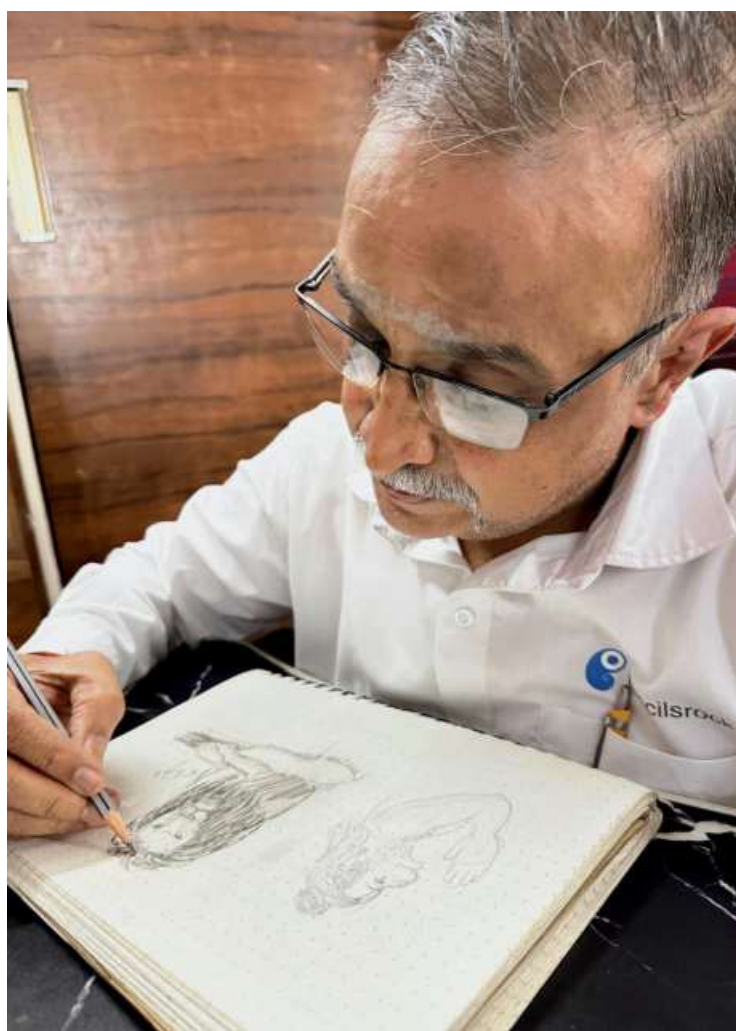
PRINCE FREDERICK

Raghunath Krishna is the flywheel driving an initiative by alumni of The Hindu Higher Secondary School in Triplicane, the 1986 batch of the school, self-christened Big Street Boys. If the christening had happened in 1986 the day after the farewell, they need not tender any explanation to Backstreet Boys (est. 1993). If so, the American pop boy band would owe the boys from Triplicane a clear explanation.

On the topic at hand, Raghunath's felt-tip caricature pen (sometimes, a pencil or a piece of charcoal) scripts what would easily pass off as a “reaching-out, giving-back” story. Trained by Raghunath, that pen has a demonstrated history of coaxing grotesquely attention-grabbing images out of the mundane. It is now at the centre of a visual vulture conservation project for school students.

These children would be reminded every day about the bird that is lagging in the numbers game. Raghunath has designed labels to be pasted on school notebooks, and these carry caricatured representations of vultures, portraying them not as carrion-devouring toughies, but cute and cuddle-worthy pets. The facts can be fed to the children later, get their attention first; that thinking is evidently at play.

He observes that his caricature pen is swayed by two philosophies: draw with the a symbol of the target group pinned in the tack board in front of you; and two, no design that ever was effective was put the viewer to sleep, overpowering



them with ennui. Hence no posters larded with data, just plain caricatures; info posters are necessary, but work only on the follow-up trail. Raghunath's lessons on caricaturing animals for conservation can be viewed at his You Tube Channel, Pencils Rock Academy.

On June 18, the alumni group

distributed a huge set of these labels to students of Olcott school at Besant Nagar and Raghunath spoke about why the vulture's place in the ecosystem cannot be filled by any other creature. Any discussion about vulture is loud on biomagnification: how man-made chemical toxins enter the food chain and af-

▼ Raghunath Krishna; and at a session at Olcott school in Besant Nagar.
PHOTOS: S.R. RAGHUNATHAN AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



fect vultures as they pick at carrion.

This resources to create the labels were generated by the alumni group, members chipping in with contributions. Raghunath points out he would want the initiative to be extended to other schools including his alma mater, The Hindu Higher Secondary School, and that would depend on whether help beyond the batch is forthcoming.

This is not the first time Raghunath is interacting with students on the subject of species conservation. He is a brand strategist working with environment and nature conservation NGOs and creates awareness about the subject among communities living in the creases

between wildlife sanctuaries, particularly the younger generations in their midst. He has done this work among forest-based communities in Tamil Nadu, Kerala and Karnataka.

Among his other significant campaigns are the one on tiger reserves and another on elephants. Titled Elephany, the latter (an art project for children executed during the pandemic) celebrated jumbos, creatures seemingly breathed into life just for the felt-tip caricature pen.

Says Raghunath: “Every elephant is a gardener par excellence. In its lifetime, one without any major twists, an elephant will plant 18 lakh trees/ plants, spreading seeds through its dung.”



Priya Grace Christabell receives the citation from Uma Shanker, president, and Shalini Gopalakrishna, treasurer of the Indian Montessori Center (IMC), Bengaluru. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Montessori educators receive directorship award

Hema Sridharan and Priya Grace Christabell, faculty with Indian Montessori Training Courses (IMTC) - Chennai, were recently conferred with the ‘Independent Directorship Award’.

The directorship is awarded to educators after a rigorous process that includes the submission of theoretical papers and practical training experience, both of which ex-

tends for a few years.

The citations were presented by Uma Shanker, president, and Shalini Gopalakrishna, treasurer of the Indian Montessori Center (IMC), Bengaluru.

An IMC-certified director of training courses can set up a teacher training centre, which is an important milestone in further spreading Montessori education in

Tamil Nadu, a release stated.

The first teacher training centre in Tamil Nadu was set up in 1998 by Uma Shanker. Till date, over 150 teachers employed in Greater Chennai Corporation schools have undergone the Montessori teacher training conducted by IMTC-Chennai and Kalvi Trust for Research and Education, the release added.

Crooners beat commuting blues on Chennai's suburban trains

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN



A Methuselah among train singing groups

Every day, at set hours in the morning and evening, a compartment in the local electric train on the Chennai Central-Tiruvallur suburban line morphs into a concert hall. Listening in to the voices from this decades-old amateur train singing group

On the 7.30 a.m. local from Tiruvallur to Chennai Central, compartment three (third from the motorman's cab) doubles as a jukebox. A one-off model, this jukebox cranks out live singing performances. First-timers are usually gobsmacked to hear vocal notes drowning the whir and whine of the suburban electric train and rising in cadence over the occasional clatter of its wheels. No professional singers in sight; nor trained musicians. And the singing can sometimes get ragged around the edges. Commuters are the voices, untrained, occasionally coarse-textured, but irresistibly real.

It is a group forged on the commute. People drawn from different walks of life, different offices, staying together on the commute because they have been singing together as the train carries them to work and home again. It is an "encore" on the 6.25 p.m. local from Chennai Central

to Tiruvallur, the group flexing their vocal cords again. This is a motivational reminder that between deadlines at work and chores at home, there is always a seat of relaxation to nestle into.

This "commuters choir" is as loosely defined as its daily playlist (Tamil and occasionally Hindi songs) and its roster of singers. As in any word-of-mouth tradition, there are multiple strands to its identity and history. Singers would reel off a diversity of names for the group. Some have given it a moniker, "Rail Ragam". Others hold on to a more idealised vision of it, choosing to keep it nameless, thereby deepening mystique. I. Jayaseelan, an advocate and a key member of the group, has an origin story for the group that melds with cosmogony upholding Big Bang Theory. "Nobody started it; the group was born suddenly. Nobody knows how," observes Jayaseelan. P. Venugopal, who joined the group in 2003 and contributes to the music

on the move with banjos, takes a "creationist" view, pointing out that a railway employee started it, and the young group was dandled and nourished by a diversity of commuters. Points of agreement include the group's longevity, close to 40 years old. Composition of the group: staff from Government Hospital, Secretariat, LIC, Harbour, law professionals associated with the High Court and from many private enterprises as well. There is no formal membership. People hop on and off the way they would a train.

However, to be able to hold court in a crowded compartment, a voice accustomed to the scrutiny of an audience helps. Those who sing invariably are given to the habit of singing in challenging settings. Jayaseelan reveals that he has a music troupe called "Inisai Saral". Music instruments such as rhythm pads are brought in by members. Even the sides of a compartment are used as surface for drumming.

The singers on the Chennai Central- Tiruvallur suburban line

On the commute, the singers are known to be offered small gifts, usually eats, if a listener is moved by the singing. "The best gifts are not materialistic; they come as appreciation which we accept with both hands," points out Jayaseelan. "Often, listeners get so lost in the music that they miss their destination, overshooting it by a few stations. Sometimes, they deliberately miss their destination to listen in to more songs."

A train compartment is a shared space, and some commuters might want the sanctity of such spaces to be protected, along with their peace. And that would mean hey do not sign up for the impromptu concert.

"Sometimes, the singers might get carried away, and get too loud for the non-participants' comfort. There have been instances where a singer has been 'led away' by the railway police. Not arrested, just led away," says Jayaseelan.

The advocate notes "the singing will not die down; and the phenomenon is hardly unique to the Chennai Central to Tiruvallur local. There is a long-lasting singing group on the Chennai Beach to Tambaram suburban line; and another on the Chennai Beach to Tiruvallur line."

What is more delectable than the singing in these train groups is the notes of camaraderie and relaxation that are struck silently. Strangers become companions. Weary commuters find solace. An old soul feels renewed, breathing in the air of nostalgia.

For details about the group, call 94441 07353

This unit changed tracks

From devotional to film songs, Pallavaram Return to Tambaram Local, this train commuters music group has experienced notable shifts but is still 'singing' strong

Suburban train singing groups rarely change tracks. Almost everything, from the timings and compartment to the route and genre, is "notated" with indelible ink. And the settings and processes continue without a semitone of variation. The singing group on the Tambaram to Chennai Beach suburban line strayed off this predictable course.

First up, the route. Around 30 years ago, the group whirled into soundscape on the Pallavaram Return, a service originating at Pallavaram station at 9.30 a.m. and screeching to a halt at Chennai Beach. Om Balachandran, employed as public relations inspector at the Anna Salai post office, is by his own admission, a member of this group not by the strength of his vocal cords, but his cochlea. He can sound Descartian if he chose to: "I listen, therefore I am (a member of this group)." And this is what Balachandran "the listener" has to say: the route changed around the pandemic when "Pallavaram Return" service was waved into retirement. Since then the group is associated with the 8.50 a.m. Tambaram local. The "mobile concert hall" is the third compartment from the guard van.

"Still, a majority of the members are from Pallavaram and Chromepet," Balachandran emphasises. The group has had another notable shift: from hymns to hits. In its early days, devotional songs were its staple. And then filmy earworms (Ta-



The group in 2011 when it was called Pallavaram Return Singing Group; and (below) now as Tambaram Local Singing Group. The music ends every day at Chennai Beach. PHOTOS: A.MURALIDHARAN AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

mil and occasional Hindi songs) wriggled into the centre stage. Now, there is a mix with film songs in a predominant position. However, every singing session is ushered in with a devotional song.

S. Harishankar, whose daily commute transports him to the Secretariat where he is in a team that takes care of all matters pertaining to the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly, the premises and the processes, has been a long-time member. He has reasons to view this compartment as a relief, even an escape from the mundane and persistent burdens of life. And also as a space for companionship.

When it burst on the scene, the group was composed of friends, ten of them. And the number stands at around 30, a clutch of them (three to four) trained for professional stage singing. The thirty does not account for the silent participants, seemingly distant but engrossed in the proceedings.

In fact, the fandom of this group, nicknamed

"The Train Friends", stretches across tracks. I. Jayaseelan, an advocate with the Madras High Court who is part of the singing group on the Chennai Central to Tiruvallur suburban line, detains from his regular commute to board this train just for the singing.

Besides the camaraderie among members, which is extended to counterparts from singing groups on other suburban locals such as Jayaseelan, there is respect for fellow passengers, even those frowning at the "concert". Balachandran explains: "Occasionally, when the singing group receives a negative response, even if one passenger objects to the singing, saying it prevents them from having a quiet journey, we immediately stop singing." It takes courage to pursue one's passion, and social consciousness to keep it tempered. This group has evidently got this two-sided equation uncannily right.

'Yoga Parks' to come up at two iconic institutions in Chennai

Under an Ayush initiative, Regional Research Institute of Unani Medicine in Royapuram and National Institute of Siddha in Tambaram are clearing the decks for the establishment of spaces that promote yoga



PHOTO SANDEEP SAXENA

LIFFYTHOMAS

Two institutions from Chennai – National Institute of Siddha in Tambaram and Regional Research Institute of Unani Medicine in Royapuram – figure among the list of spaces in various that are to be promoted as Yoga Parks.

An initiative of the Ministry of Ayush, Government of India, Yoga Park Portal encourages corporates, resident welfare associations and other like-minded groups to promote these spaces for wellness programmes.

As on the date, the portal has more than 60 parks across cities registered with them with four being from Tamil Nadu.

A 'Yoga Park' would serve as a dedicated space developed within existing 'parks' in both rural and urban areas, with support from Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) initiatives of companies.

These parks are designed to provide a structured, accessible, and inclusive environment for the regular practice of yoga and wellness activities, says a note on the website. The initiative aims to promote healthy lifestyles, community participation, and preventive healthcare by offering nearby residents a serene and well-equipped space for daily yoga practice and holistic well-being.

On June 21, which is International Day of Yoga, both these institutions will be hosting Yoga Day and other wellness programmes.

The huge space that these institutions have is one reason why they easily qualify to be promoted as Yoga Parks.

National Institute of Siddha, for instance, is spread across 14 acres and runs a medical college along with the hospital. Yoga is offered as a speciality and is also prescribed to patients. The Institute is opening up its campus for corporates to invest in improving its infrastructure. "We have identified an open area roughly measuring 200 sq metre within our campus, which can be promoted for yoga, so we have registered for funding under CSR," says a senior staff with the Institute.

For more details, visit <https://yoga.ayush.gov.in/yogapark>



GANGA SRIDHAR

Sustainable Sparks drive, an initiative launched on World Environment Day 2026 by EcoKconnectors, invited individuals and businesses to share eco-friendly practices. Entries from a diversity of communities poured in. And they were wide-ranging, straddling segregation and composting, terrace gardens and upcycling and solar electrification, water conservation, the how-to of avoiding food waste and traditional eco-friendly cooking entries. Each practice was celebrated as a spark capable of igniting many more sustainable actions. Through videos and writeups, EcoKconnectors showcased these inspiring contributions, motivating neighbourhoods to embrace sustainability and recognise the power of small steps in shaping a greener future.

The sparks were slotted into different categories.

Garden Sparks

Amidst Chennai's rising concrete skyline, a few cherished homes and thoughtful apartments still nurture green sanctuaries. These spaces echo ancient practices: feeding cows with rice water, leaving bowls for birds and strays, and offering fruits to squirrels. Within them thrive Mango, Jamun, Neem, Jackfruit, Guava, coconut and Plantain trees, creating forest-like havens for chirping birds and playful squirrels. Our Green Sparks contributors include Shameem from Raja Street, Dr. R. Chandrasekharan, Deepa Raghunath, Lalitha Iyer, Ravi Kumar from RA Puram, Sushela from Neelangarai and Mala Ramesh from Krishnagiri beautifully extend their garden from the ground to the terrace and balcony, showcasing efficient space use. Herbs, fruiting, and flowering

Sparks of sustainability

Following an announcement on World Environment day, residents of Mandaveli, R.A. Puram, Mylapore and Adyar have clogged EcoKconnectors' inbox with accounts and images of their green lifestyles



▼ Deepa Raghunath under her solar rooftop; Ravi Kumar at his garden; and Bhuvana Pasupathi with her indigenous composter upcycled from an old plastic stool. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



plants thrive there, providing puja flowers every day straight from their terrace.

Composting Sparks

Savitha Suresh Kanna proudly showcased her three-tier Kumbha composter and her harvest, while Bhuvana Pasupathi creatively repurposed an old enclosed stool into a composter. Ravi Kumar shared his home composting methods.

Despite busy schedules, they compost puja flowers and kitchen waste, reaping rich, earthy compost. Deepa from Gopalapuram says: "I practise eco-friendly habits daily such as recycling newspapers, washed and dried Aavin packets plastics, segregating kitchen waste, and donating usable clothes, bags and shoes to orphanages or old age homes".

The Munira Shoaib Welfare Trust organised a Waste Collection and Segregation Drive at Voora Oceans 27, Tondiarpet, promoting responsible waste management through awareness and participation, inspiring communities toward sustainable living practices and shared their community level sustainability initiative as a spark with us. It sends a powerful reminder that even the busiest among us can carve out moments to nurture the environment.

Water Sparks

Water conservation sparks by reusing RO outlet water for mopping the floor and washing purposes was shared by V. Ramakrishna and Ishita.

Upcycling Sparks

Upcycling Sparks Vidya Madi-vannan embodies the spirit of Best out of Waste. For over a decade, she has composted household waste and transformed discarded items into creative art forms. Choosing ecofriendly products, she avoids plastic and embraces bio enzymes safe for earth and people. She also uses reusable period panties and upcycles wedding invitations into earrings, paper scraps

into bowls, medicine bottles and broken mirrors into décor, and old wood into name boards, turning waste into sustainable beauty.

Solar Sparks

Deepa Raghunath of R.A. Puram and Susheela Bala of Neelangarai showcased solar rooftops, proving Chennai's abundant sunlight makes solar electrification essential, drastically reducing electricity bills sustainably.

Cooking Sparks

Kanthi Neelamegham of Raja Street shared a video using the traditional Ammi kall for grinding, saving electricity, enhancing taste, and keeping herself flexible and fit.

Sustainable Business Sparks

"Rain Bio Enzymes" Priyadarshini showcased sustainable business practices, creating handmade natural soaps and cleaning liquids with bioenzymes which are eco-friendly, cost-effective alternatives to expensive chemical detergents.

"Three Square Meals," Rohan runs a cloud kitchen operating from Adyar, delivers comforting corporate and daily meals in compostable bagasse boxes lined with banana leaves eliminating plastics and redefining sustainable food packaging.

"Aparna" a Mylapore based garment store and workshop embodies sustainability. Powered by solar energy, built with reclaimed wood, terracotta, recycled plastic and natural stone, it minimises waste. Her garments use natural fabrics, recycled cotton tags, cornstarch packaging, and scrap fabric repurposed into purses or kids' clothes—reflecting simplicity, responsibility, and ecofriendly values throughout.

Daniel's inspired SWM Spark emphasises that what feels excess to one can be a need for another. During his London project, he discovered the Olio and Trash Nothing apps, where volunteers and individuals share surplus food, grocery and items instantly, preventing waste. From rice to fans, everything found purpose. He believes such platforms should expand globally, making responsible sharing effortless. He hopes similar systems will help connect his usable cycle and other items to the right recipients in India as well. We received sustainability sparks from far and wide and this one was all the way from Mala Ramesh of Krishnagiri. Mala says: "I am a small scale farmer trying to grow forest trees along with fruit trees for birds in an organic method. We have reduced the use of cement by opting for compressed stabilised earthen bricks in our house. Water is conserved in pond, swale apart from soak pits all around. In addition, the natural gradients in the land have been restructured to direct rainwater to recharge bore wells. These are our small contributions to afforestation".



‘Meena aunty’ remembered at green drive

On June 17, a sapling plantation drive was conducted during the morning assembly at Chettinad Vidyasharam.

Students enthusiastically participated by do-

nating saplings, including ornamental, herbal and medicinal varieties. As a symbolic gesture, three saplings were planted on the campus, reinforcing the school’s commitment to sustainability and environmental

responsibility.

According to a press release, the programme served as a meaningful reminder of Meena Muthiah, fondly remembered as Meena Aunty, and her enduring legacy of nurturing both young minds and

the environment. The late founder of the school was a passionate advocate of environmental conservation and regularly initiated eco-friendly programmes that instilled a love for nature among students, added the release.

Flower showers, cards and bouquets

That is how freshers at Sri Kanyaka Parameswari Arts and Science College for Women were welcomed



A programme was conducted to welcome freshers at Sri Kanyaka Parameswari Arts and Science College for Women on June 18. The event also served as

an occasion to familiarise the newly admitted students with the college environment.

Seniors greeted juniors with flower showers, greeting cards and bou-

quets. The senior students also presented vibrant dance performances, making the occasion memorable for the newcomers, said a press release.

The event concluded successfully, marking the beginning of a new chapter in the lives of the freshers as they became a part of the “Kanyaka legacy”, the release added.

Kanchi pontiff visits P.S. Senior Secondary School



P.S. Senior Secondary School had the rare honour of welcoming Sankara Vijayendra Saraswathi on the evening of June 10, 2026. The visit, organised by the school management, was one of the most significant events of the school’s Golden Jubilee celebrations.

The programme commenced with a traditional “Poorna Kumbam” accorded to “His Holiness”. Students, staff members, parents and devotees gathered in large numbers to seek his blessings. The school correspondent P. S. Prabhakar wel-

comed the gathering. The secretary of P. S. Education society K.V.S. Gopalakrishnan addressed the audience.

During his visit, His Holiness blessed the school management, teaching and non-teaching staff, and the entire student community. He commended the school in imparting value-based education and in shaping the students holistically.

Students of Classes X and XII received special blessings and words of encouragement as they prepare for important academic milestones in their lives.

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Structured handwriting programme for CBSE students

The Central Board of Secondary Education answer sheets from the current academic year will be evaluated digitally. This means that the process involves scanning answer sheets online. The handwriting of students of classes X, XI and XII has to be clear, legible and presen-

tation worthy.

The students have to understand the CBSE online marking system, prepare to focus on legible handwriting, and work on presentation skills, in addition to writing the right answers, a press release said.

Thejomaya is offering a structured training pro-

gramme focused on legibility, speed, and effective visual representation. The programme involves pre-evaluation of existing handwriting and combines practical exercises, personalised guidance, and age-appropriate level books and techniques. For details, call 9381329450, 944467977.

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Bike captain on a mission

Rapido bike taxi operator 'Karate' Mahalakshmi gets back home in the wee hours to ensure other women have a safe ride home late in the night



Mahalakshmi has worked with various institutions as a karate instructor including Queen Mary's College.
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

LIFFY THOMAS

Women wary of travelling at night with a male driver has someone to turn to: Rapido 'Captain' Mahalakshmi Ramalingam. She offers bike rides on Rapido late in the night. She is known as 'Karate Mahalakshmi' for a reason: she has been teaching and practising karate for two decades.

"From 9 p.m. to 1 a.m. my bookings are reserved for women, especially those returning from a long-distance trip alighting at Koyambedu bus terminus or Perambur railway station and unable to get a bus," says the resident of Mogappair who has been with the ride-hailing app for the last two years.

Prior to that, Mahalakshmi had

worked as assistant karate instructor with various schools including Velammal Group of Schools, Chennai Public School and Queen Mary's College, where she is often greeted by students who appreciate her influence as a trainer.

Her journey into martial art training began when she was 19, her mother enrolling her in a karate class in the neighbourhood for self-defence. "I lost my father when I was 17 and that pro-

tective feeling was missing at home. I was overweight for my age with thyroid-related complaints, and people made fun of me," says Mahalakshmi.

Although karate empowered and boosted her confidence, she faced many hardships at home and in the workplace.

A school dropout, Mahalakshmi had to work to support her family, being the eldest child. She started by taking up odd jobs. Working as a karate instructor did not address the financial crunch.

"During April and May, we would not get any salaries as schools were not having classes," she says. Later, through a friend she got to know about Rapido. Mahalakshmi says the job has its challenges but on the upside, it offers flexibility.

"I have done close to 6,000 rides with both male and female riders. In some situations you have to be tough and certain others, it is better to ignore the taunts," says the captain who takes 10-15 rides a day.

Genuine expressions of thankfulness from women she had safely dropped at night serve as a motivation factor for Mahalakshmi.

A fellow journalist with *The Hindu* has been a regular rider with Mahalakshmi. She has ferried her many a time for a column featuring Chennai's night life.

Mahalakshmi's first love remains karate and she wants to impart self-defence training to women at Rapido so that they can take late night rides.

In her view, driving and martial arts are indispensable skills for every woman. Mahalakshmi is being helped by well wishers to fulfil her dream of establishing a self-defence karate academy for women and girls.



Ticket booking time reduced to 5 seconds in CUMTA's app

The Chennai One App of Chennai Unified Metropolitan Transport Authority has introduced a new feature called "One Click Payment: CUMTA UPI." According to a press release, the feature reduces the ticket booking time from 60 seconds to five seconds. Also, commuters can avail this facility to get the first ticket for ₹1.

CUMTA encourages the public to use this facility to travel seamlessly using the Chennai One App, adds the press release.



Celebration of music at Pondy Bazaar today

Marking World Music Day on June 21, Greater Chennai Corporation, in association with On the Streets of Chennai (OTS), is organising "World Music Day Gig Marathon", which will play out from 7.00 a.m. to 10 p.m. at the Big Bazaar entrance of Pondy Bazaar. The music event will feature around 100 artistes.

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